

Your photo library, on the drive.

shoebox is a small program that lives on your external drive next to your photos. It indexes them, shows them in a fast timeline in your browser, and helps you tag, sort, import and de-duplicate, without ever copying them or touching their metadata.



Originals stay untouched



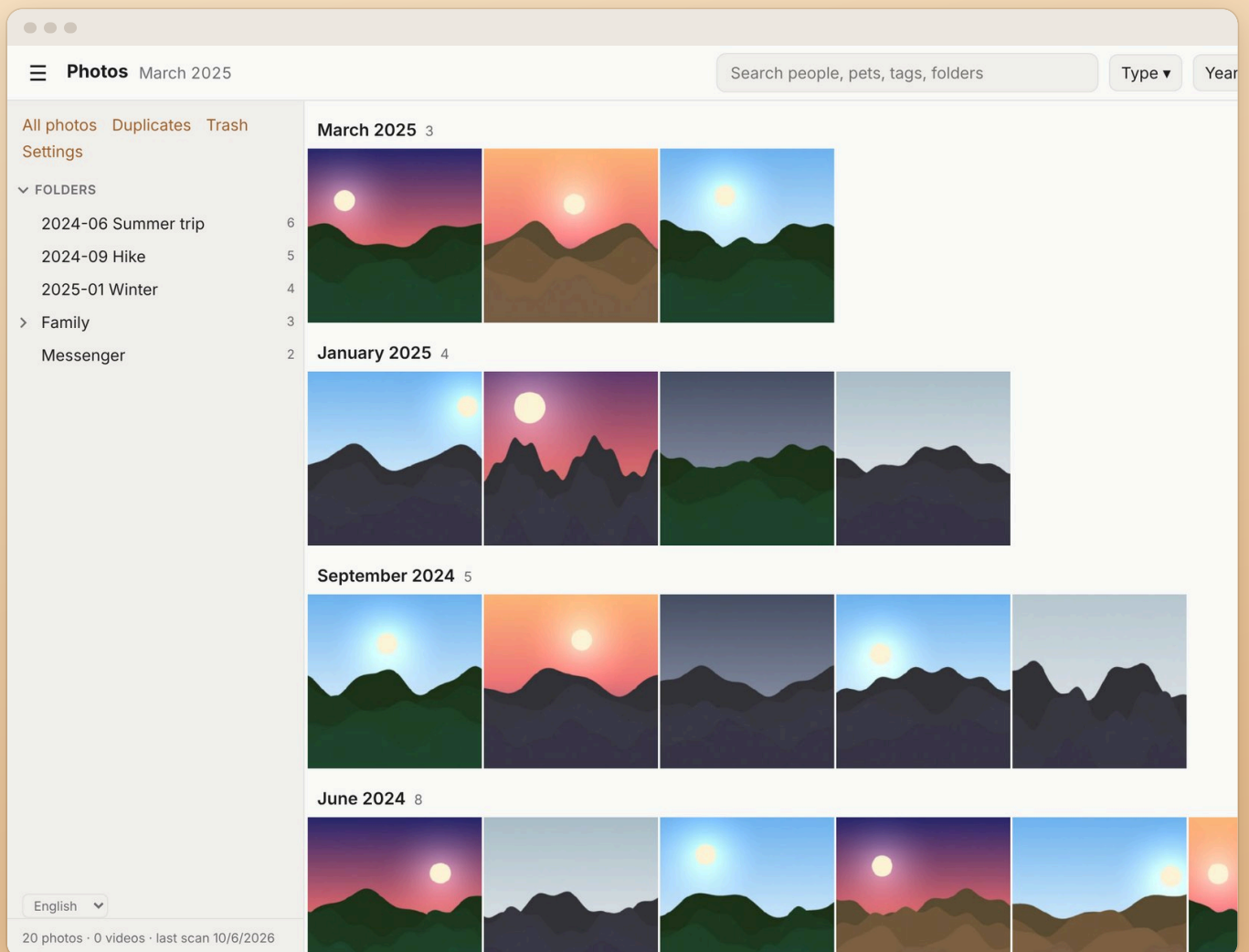
Lives on your drive



Private: no cloud, no account



Browse from the iPad too



What shoebox can do

One page in your browser, a timeline of everything on the drive.



Timeline

All photos and videos by month, with a year jump, folder tree and a viewer with full-size info.



Search & filter

Type a person, pet, tag or folder. Combine several as chips. Filter by photos, videos or Live Photos.



Tags

Your own tags on many photos at once. Folders count as tags too. Stored in the index, never in the photos.



Move & organise

Move photos to a folder (created if needed). RAW, Live Photo and sidecar files travel along.



Import

Drop photos and videos into the window; they land in a "YYYY-MM Event" folder and keep their dates.



Duplicates

Finds identical, resized, edited and look-alike photos. You review; the best copy always stays.



Safe trash

Deleted photos go to a trash on the drive. Put them back, or delete them for good.



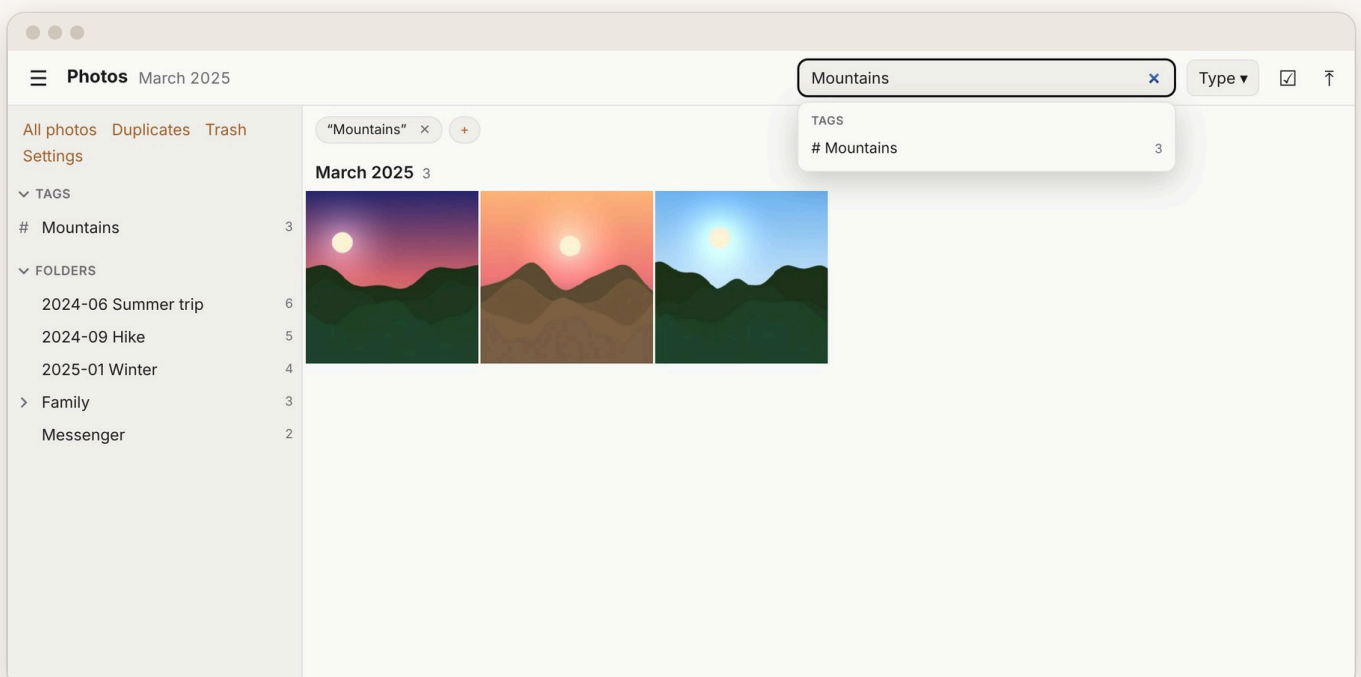
People & pets

Optional recognition groups faces, cats and dogs. You name them; shoebox suggests the rest.



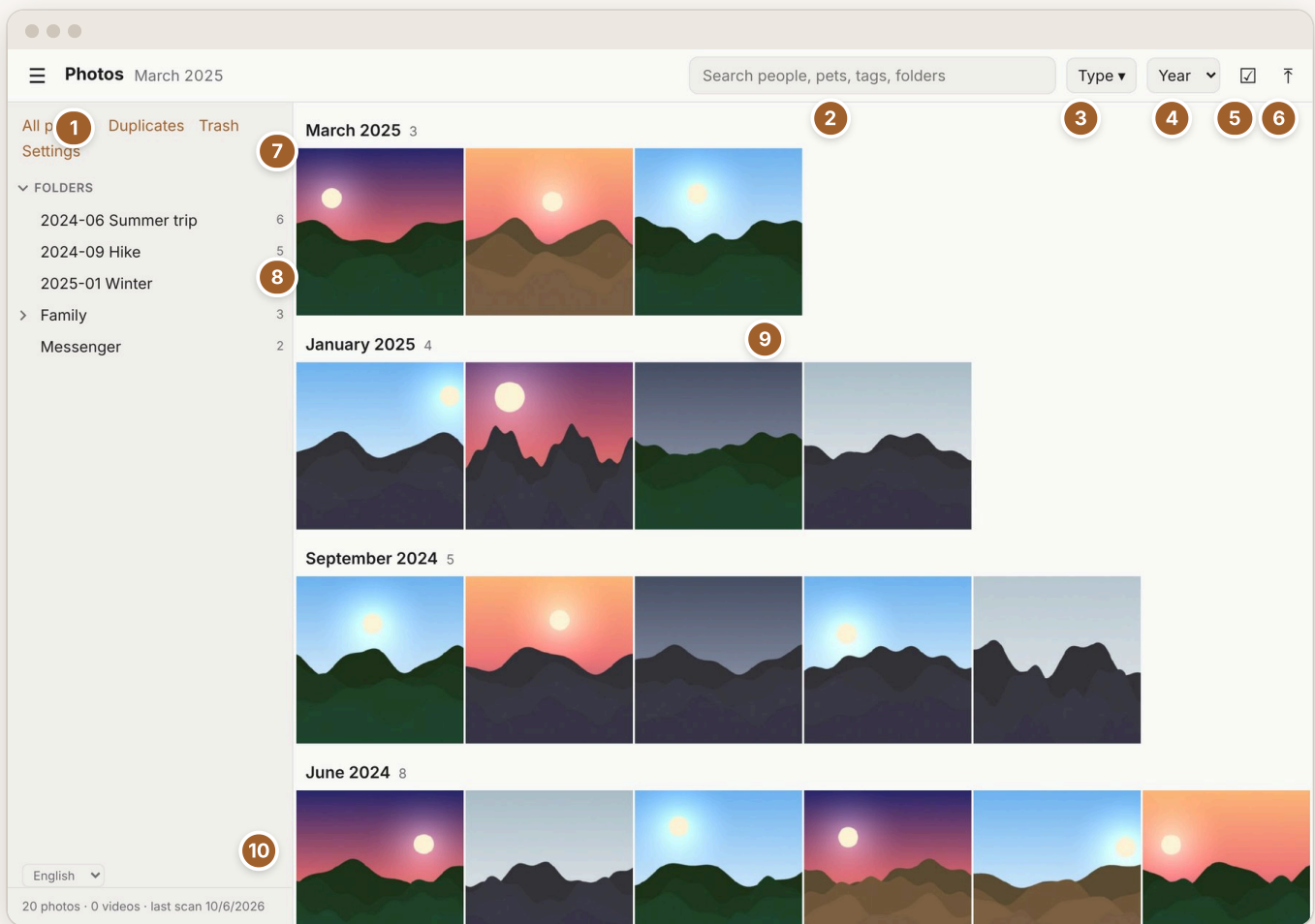
Several drives

Open more drives side by side, see which are backups, and check that a backup is complete.



The screen at a glance

Everything is on one page. Here is where things are.



- 1 Folders menu**
≡ shows or hides the sidebar on narrow screens.
- 2 Search box**
People, pets, tags and folders; pick several to combine them.
- 3 Type**
Show only photos, videos or Live Photos.
- 4 Year**
Jump straight to a year.
- 5 Select** ☒
Pick photos to move, tag or trash.
- 6 Import** ↑
Add photos and videos from this computer or the iPad.
- 7 Quick links**
All photos · Duplicates · Trash · Settings.
- 8 Folders**
Your folders, with counts. Tags, Faces and Drives appear here when you have them.
- 9 Timeline**
Months with counts. Click a photo to open the viewer.
- 10 Language & status**
Switch English / German; see scan, thumbnail and drive status.

A TYPICAL SESSION

Plug in the drive and double-click **Start shoebox**. **Scan** (quick when little has changed) and open the photo app. **Import** new photos into an event folder, then tag and sort. Look at **Duplicates** now and then, and run the **Backup check** after every backup.

Get started in three steps

macOS, Intel (10.13 or newer) and Apple Silicon. Nothing to install.

1 Put it on the drive

Unpack **shoebox-macos.tar.gz** from the release. Copy **shoebox-macos** and **Start shoebox.command** to the top folder of your photo drive (next to your photo folders). Optional: the **recognizer** folder for faces.

2 Start the launcher

Double-click **Start shoebox.command**. A Terminal window opens (leave it open) and the launcher appears in your browser. If macOS asks, right-click the file and choose **Open**.

3 Scan, then open

Add your drive (click it, or type `/Volumes/MyDrive`), press **Scan**, then **Start photo app**. The first scan reads every file once and takes a while on a big drive; later scans only look at what changed.

LAUNCHER TASKS

Scan	find new, moved and changed photos
Verify	check that nothing was lost or damaged
Recognize	find faces (and, with Recognize pets, cats and dogs)
Backup check	is the 2nd folder a complete copy of the 1st?

The screenshot shows the 'shoebox' launcher interface. It has a title bar with three dots. Below the title is a subtitle: 'Your photo library on this drive. Nothing is copied or changed in your photos.'

1 · Where are your photos?

Drives or photo folders (type a path, press Enter to add it)

`/Volumes/Photos` x Add another folder...

Detected drives, click to add:

Photos Backup

A check mark marks drives that already have a shoebox library.

2 · What should shoebox do?

Scan: find new, moved and changed photos

Verify: check that nothing was lost or damaged

Recognize: find the faces in your photos

Recognize pets: find cats and dogs; they show up among the faces

Face stats: how recognition went

Backup check: is the 2nd folder a complete copy of the 1st?

☐ Quick (Scan: skip full hashes · Verify: size and date only)

☐ Recognize: also look for faces lying down (slower)

☐ Backup check: also re-read the backup drive (finds bit rot; slow)

Scan finished

0 worked 0 failed 0 added · 0 moved · 0 changed · 0 missing

Results per file ☐ only problems

No files.

► Messages

3 · Open your photos

Start photo app

The photo app starts only when you press this button. Scan first if this is a new drive.

Language: English

The launcher: 1 choose the drive or folder, 2 pick a task, 3 open the photo app.

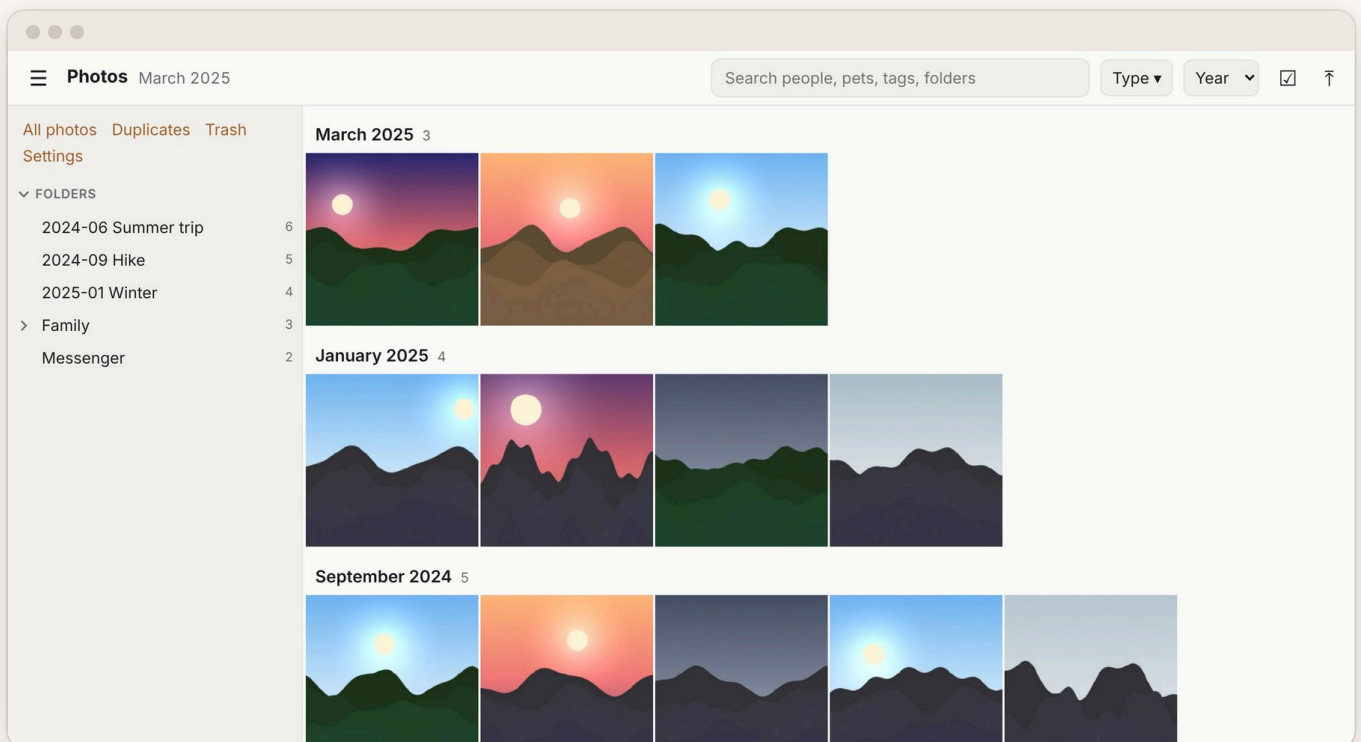
GOOD TO KNOW

- Videos get preview images if you put a static **ffmpeg** next to the program (`.shoebox/bin/ffmpeg`). Without it, the browser grabs a frame instead.
- shoebox keeps its index and thumbnails in a hidden `.shoebox` folder on the drive, so the drive can move to another computer.
- Closing the Terminal window stops shoebox.

The app speaks English and German: pick the language at the bottom of the sidebar.

Browse and view

Scroll through the timeline, jump by year, open a photo.



The timeline: months, folders, search, type filter and year jump.

Timeline

Photos are grouped by capture date, newest first. The **Year** menu jumps; the month heading shows where you are. Photos without a capture date use the folder's month.

Folders

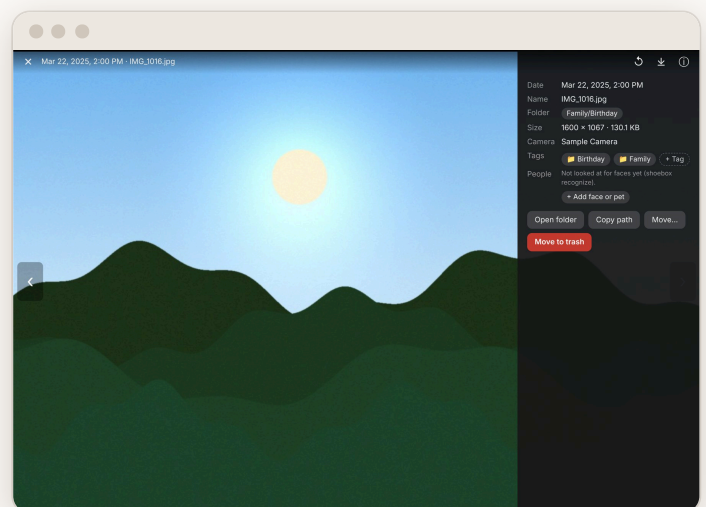
The sidebar mirrors the folders on your drive. Click one to see only its photos. Rename or move a folder from its chip.

Viewer

Click a photo. ⓘ opens the info panel: date, camera, size, tags, people, and buttons to open the folder or copy the path.

Rotate

r turns left, **Shift+R** right. For JPEGs this changes only the two bytes of the rotation flag; for other formats the turn exists in shoebox only.



The viewer with its info panel.

KEYBOARD IN THE VIEWER

← →	previous / next
i	info panel
r · Shift+R	rotate left / right
Esc · Space	close

Find and organise

Search, select, tag and move: all of it works on many photos at once.

Search

Type in the search box: suggestions appear for tags, people and folders. Pick several and they become chips that narrow the result; × removes one, **Clear all** starts over.

Select

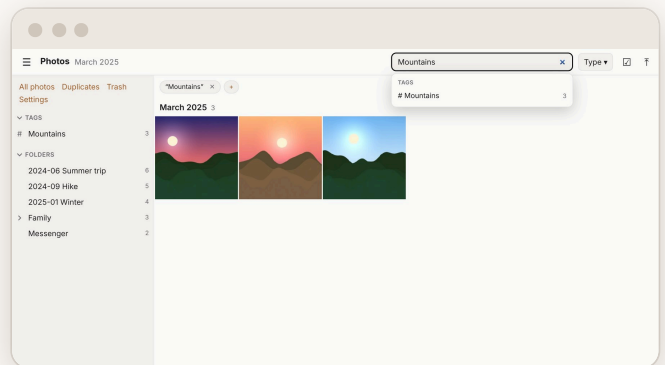
Press **⌘**, then click photos (Shift-click for a range; on the iPad just tap). "Select all" on a month heading takes the whole month.

Tag

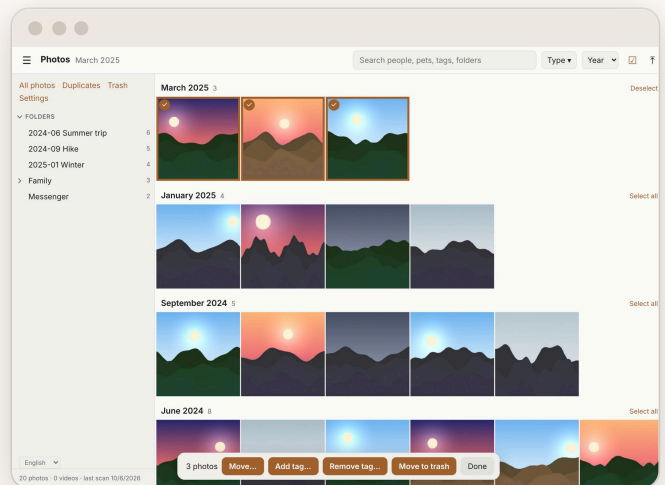
Add tag... puts your own tag on the selection. Tags live in shoebox's index, never in the photo files.

Move

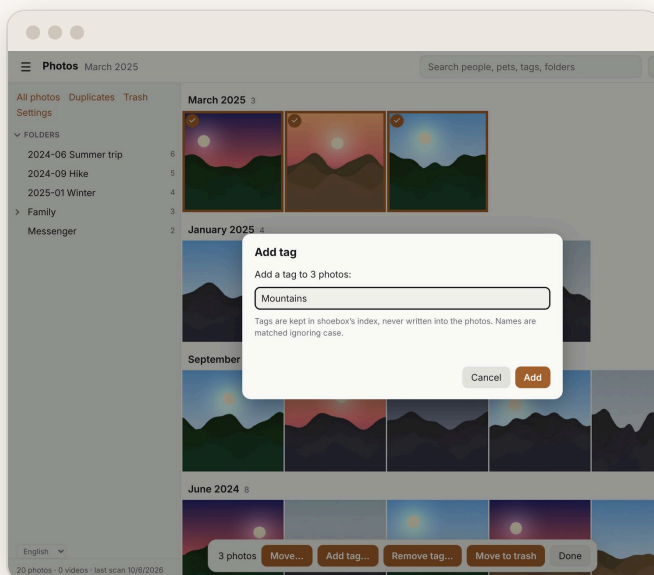
Move... asks for a folder. New folders are created, nothing is ever overwritten, and RAW, Live Photo and sidecar files move along. "Keep tags" decides whether the photos' own tags go with them.



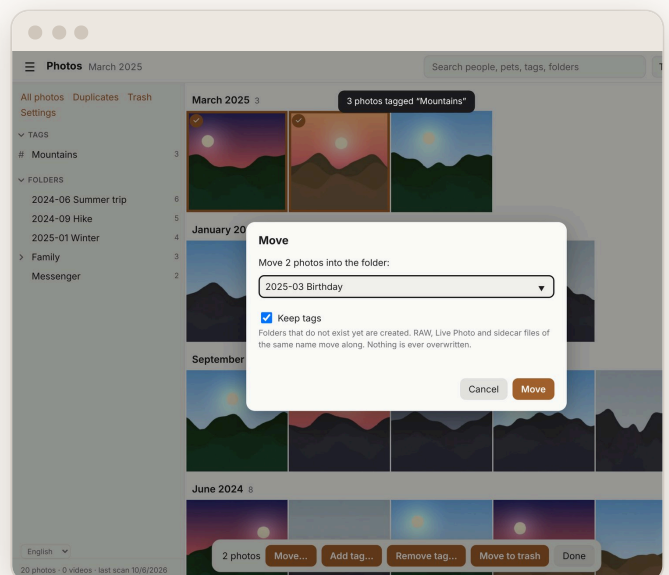
Suggestions as you type.



Three photos selected; the bar offers Move, Tag and Trash.



Adding a tag.



Moving into a new event folder.

Import, duplicates and trash

Import

Press **↑** (or drop files on the window). Choose year, month and an event name: files go to **YYYY-MM Event**, keep their dates, and files already in the library are skipped.

Duplicates

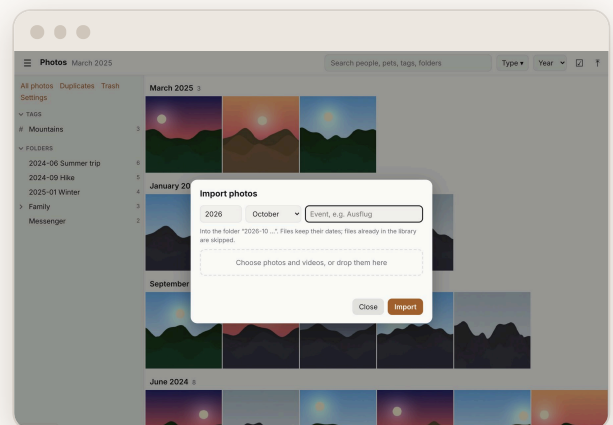
Duplicates lists four kinds: identical, same photo in another size, original and edited, and look-alikes. Tick **delete this copy** on what you want gone; the best file stays and at least one per group always does. Tags and capture dates of a removed copy carry over.

Shortcuts

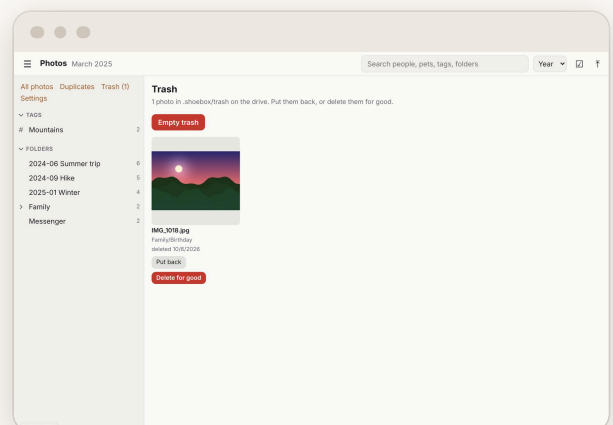
Clear Same Folder Copies and **Clear Lower Quality Copies** clean up the clear-cut cases in one go. **Different photos** and **Versions of one photo** record your decision so the group does not return.

Trash

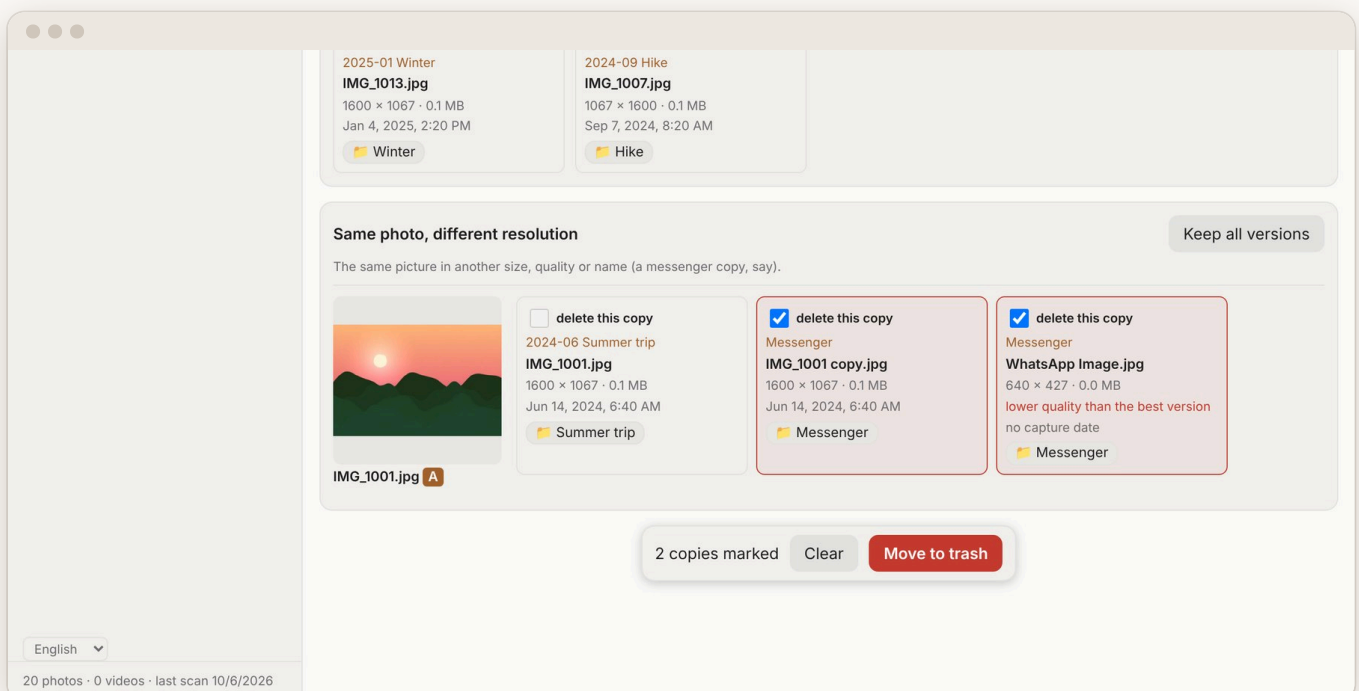
Nothing is deleted right away. Trashed photos wait in **.shoebox/trash** on the drive: **Put back** or **Delete for good**.



Import dialog.



The trash page.



Duplicates: a pre-ticked messenger copy next to its original.

People, pets, drives and the iPad

People & pets (optional)

Install the recognizer once

(`recognizer/install.sh /Volumes/MyDrive`), then run **Recognize** in the launcher. A **Faces** section appears in the sidebar. Name a card under **Unnamed**, then confirm (✓) or reject (✗) the suggestions. Group people, merge duplicates of a person, and draw a box around a face that was missed. Cats and dogs work the same way.

Several drives

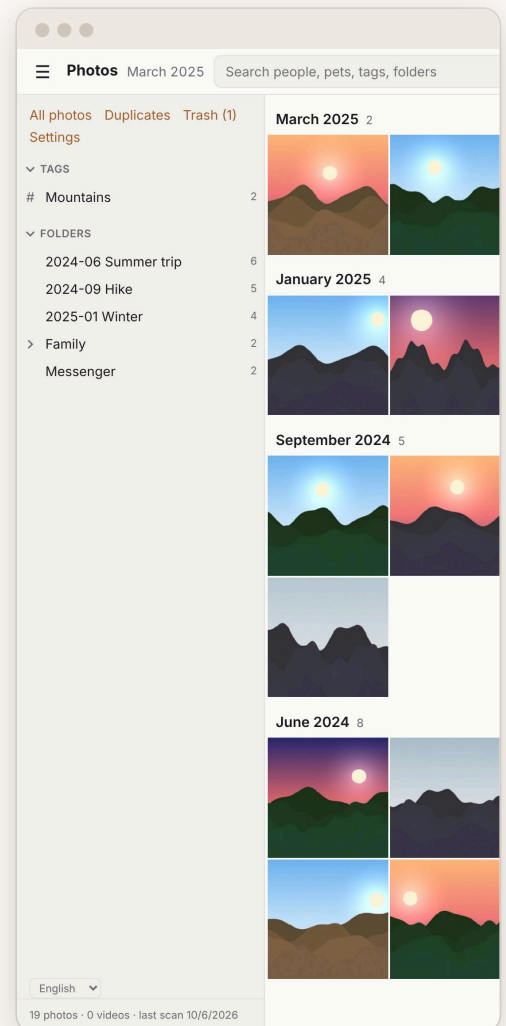
Start with more than one folder and each drive appears in the sidebar. **All drives** shows backups, photos that exist on more than one drive, and people across drives. A drive that is unplugged is shown as offline.

Backup check

Choose the original first and the backup second. shoebox compares the two indexes (no photo is read) and lists what is not on the backup yet, what differs and what exists only on the backup. *Also re-read the backup* finds bit rot.

iPad & other devices

In Terminal: `shoebox serve /Volumes/MyDrive --lan`. It prints an address and a PIN; open the address in Safari on the same Wi-Fi and enter the PIN once. Swipe in the viewer, tap to select.



On the iPad the same page works with touch.

COMMAND LINE (OPTIONAL)

`shoebox scan <folder>`

index new, moved and changed files

`shoebox verify <folder>`

re-read files and compare with the index

`shoebox recognize <folder> [--pets]`

find faces (and pets)

`shoebox backup <original> <backup>`

is the backup complete?

`shoebox serve <folder> [--lan] [--pin ...]`

open the photo app

Your photos are safe

The design rule is simple: shoebox reads your originals and never writes anything into them.



Read-only

Metadata, thumbnails and tags are kept in the index on the drive, never inside a photo. Capture dates and created dates never change.



Guarded

Every scan is checked: size, dates and a full hash before and after. Any difference is an error.



Only on your command

Originals change only through your actions: move, rename, trash, import. Always a rename, never a copy, and only if the file still matches the index.



Local

No cloud, no account. By default only this computer can connect; other devices need `--lan` and a PIN.

If something looks off

The grid is empty. Run `Scan` in the launcher first, then start the photo app.

New photos are missing. Scan again. It is quick: only new and changed files are read.

A video has no preview. Add `ffmpeg` (see "Good to know") and restart the photo app.

The iPad cannot connect. Same Wi-Fi? Started with `--lan`? Enter the PIN printed in Terminal. Restarting shoebox asks for the PIN again.

A drive shows as offline. Plug it in again; shoebox picks it up when you reload.

shoebox is open source · github.com/svenfritsch/shoebox